

CARDINALE

2022

NAPA VALLEY CABERNET SAUVIGNON

One of the great American novels, in my opinion, is “Sometimes a Great Notion” by Ken Kesey. It is a book that encompasses the voices of many different characters who are not always identified on the page directly but rather referenced by other characters as the book unfolds. Each character has its own voice that you, as the reader, learn and then are able to identify without being explicitly told who is speaking. Cardinale is much the same way, as each appellation acts as a character in the plot of the vintage. The plot’s complexity plays out on your palate with each sip—a truly great journey for those willing to take it.

The 2022 growing season started with a cool, dry spring. Summer weather was stable up until an intense Labor Day heatwave, which mountain air in our estate vineyards helped to mitigate somewhat. Light rains arrived mid-September. With a highly site-specific approach to weather events, we started harvesting fruit on September 8 and finished on October 7. Our wines spent just under two years in French oak.

I always blend Cardinale just before bottling because the wines change so much in barrel that if I blended them earlier, the final wine would not be as complex or as reflective of the spirit or “plot” of the vintage. The 2022 Cardinale delivers mountain power with valley floor sweetness and depth, leading with boysenberry, dark cherry, Asian spice, and a little clove. There is a lot of energy in this wine. Tannins are supportive and sleek, helping to carry the complexity of the blend. Spring Mountain fruit was excellent in 2022, so I chose our Yverdon Vineyard for the largest portion, 25% of the blend. The terroir at 2,100 feet gives us fine tannins, red fruit, and delicate floral notes. The next 22% came from Wurtele Vineyard at a lower elevation on Spring Mountain, bringing in darker fruit notes. Rhyolite Ridge on Diamond Mountain contributed a lush mid-palate sweetness. Ultimately, the wine came from 12 vineyards spanning eight distinct Napa Valley appellations, together expressing the singular story of 2022.

- CHRISTOPHER CARPENTER, WINEMAKER

WINE STATISTICS

APPELLATION: 100% Napa Valley

COMPOSITION: 97% Cabernet Sauvignon, 3% Merlot

SAUVIGNON BLANC AGING: 22 months in 100% French oak, 81% new

ALCOHOL: 14.7%

FINISHING: Unfined and Unfiltered

VINEYARD	Yverdon	Wurtele	Rhyolite Ridge	Andrew Geoffrey	Edcora	Veeder Peak	Tietjen	W.S. Keyes	Dalecio	W.S. Keyes	Van Z	Taylor	Wallis
APPELLATION	Spring Mountain District	Spring Mountain District	Diamond Mountain District	Diamond Mountain District	Atlas Peak	Mount Veeder	Rutherford	Howell Mountain	Rutherford	Howell Mountain	St. Helena	Stag Leap District	Diamond Mountain District
ELEVATION	1,800 ft.	1,000 ft.	750 ft.	1,850 ft.	1,650 ft.	1,800 ft.	100 ft.	1,825 ft.	100 ft.	1,825 ft.	150 ft.	150 ft.	1,500 ft.
SOIL	volcanic loam	volcanic loam	volcanic loam	volcanic loam	red rock soil	gravelly loam, black soils	gravelly loam	white & red volcanic/rocky loam	gravelly loam	white & red volcanic/rocky loam	gravelly loam	haire loam & bale clay loam	volcanic loam
VARIETY	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Merlot	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon	Cabernet Sauvignon
% CONTRIBUTION	25%	22%	15.5%	7%	7%	6%	4%	3%	3%	2%	2%	2%	1.5%
CONTRIBUTION TO THE BLEND	fine tannins, floral, red fruit	fine tannins, floral, red fruit	sweet, middle, some red	dark cherry, broad tannin	dark fruit minerality	blue fruit, length, backbone	middle body, cassis, floral, cocoa	dark fruit, herb, weight	red cherry, floral, some mid	dark fruit, herb, weight	middle, red/dark, lush	sweet red, dark cherry	sweet, middle, some red

98 POINTS

“So velvety, sleek, layered and composed, it’s a treat to drink now or save for later. Enjoy the complexity of a wine blended from 25 to 30 lots of mountain and valley floor sites up and down the reach of Napa Valley. Red and black fruit notes give some of the delicious fruitiness of Rutherford, while mountain grapes from Atlas Peak and cooler-climate grapes from the Stags Leap district add their own subtleties...”

- JIM GORDON, [JAMESUCKLING.COM](https://www.jamesuckling.com), DECEMBER 2024